



Ssup Waze?

Waze recently received its biggest ever update, changing its design and ease of navigation <http://dgit.in/Nv15e>



Moovit Bangalore!

Moovit, the crowdsourced public mapping service launches in Bangalore. First in India apparently <http://dgit.in/Nv15f>

Bluetooth speakers

Sameer Mitha

Souvik Das

readersletters@digit.in

Bluetooth speakers today are offering consumers a variety of features to stay at the top of their game. We've seen speakers that can double up as power banks to charge your phone, even speakers that can be paired to offer multi-channel sound. There are speakers that are waterproof too, so you can literally take them for a swim with you. All these features are great, but at the end of the day, what matters is the sound output. Do these speakers deliver their money's worth? Are the features on offer useful enough? Does it make sense to purchase a budget speaker, or would you rather save up for the crème de la crème? Let's kick things off, with the build and design of the Bluetooth speakers and in the process build up towards answering those difficult questions.

BUILD AND DESIGN

Bluetooth speakers need to be light, compact and easy to carry. They must also be built to withstand a small degree of everyday torture, too.

The Frontech JIL 3906 is a small, compact speaker shaped like a landmine. Its biggest USP is that it's waterproof, so you can take the device swimming with you, if you wish to. We have dropped the speaker a few times too, and it works just fine. Continuing with the small and compact form factor, we have the Logitech X50. It is available in a variety of vibrant colours appealing to the visual palate, but sadly, no waterproofing. The buttons on this speaker are big, and easy to access.

Moving to the Logitech X300, the speaker has a design

HOW WE TESTED

To begin with, we looked at the build and design of the speakers. The materials used and the construction quality took precedence here. Being a Bluetooth speaker, the devices need to be portable too. Keeping the weight and form factor in mind, we put the speakers through everyday scenarios, to judge them on their portability. We also checked for weather-proofing capabilities of the speakers, the ones that claimed that were.

Moving beyond the build and design, we took a look at the connectivity options on offer. Going beyond Bluetooth, NFC and auxiliary input, we took a look at microSD card support, USB support, and any other input that the speakers supported. Some of the Bluetooth speakers double up as a power bank, and the ones that do, were put to test.

Some Bluetooth speakers also have dedicated applications available on iOS and Android. These apps help you pair the speakers with your smartphone, connect multiple speakers together, or simply help you control the volume and other features of the speakers. We checked the app for platform

compatibility (iOS, Android and Windows Phone), along with checking how user-friendly the app is.

Coming to performance, we checked the number of Bluetooth devices the speaker could remember. This helps with ease of pairing, if you are using multiple devices with one Bluetooth speaker.

We also played a bunch of tracks such as Carnival of Rust, Instant Crush, Into the Night, Counting Stars and Carnival (from the movie, Whiplash) to see how the speakers performed. The speakers were judged, based on clarity, range, loudness and balance of the output audio.

Finally, for the price, we checked the box and product website for the maximum retail price, as well as online shopping portals for the best market operating price, to judge the price to performance ratio.

Finally, the best performer was decided purely based on the sound quality of the speaker. The best value was determined based on not only the audio output performance, but keeping in mind the price-to-performance ratio. The editor's pick was the speaker that appealed to the testers, the most.

similar to the UE Boom. It has three physical buttons on the top, for volume and Bluetooth. The power button is located at the rear of the speaker. Available in a bunch of bright colours, the speaker has a rubberized finish, which makes it easy to grip, and comfortable to hold in one's hands. Sadly even this little guy isn't weather proof. If the design of the X300 was simplified, it would look like the Sony SRS X2, our next entrant. The speaker has a matte, rubberized finish and is by far the simplest-looking speaker that we have, and that isn't a bad thing. The

buttons rest at the top of the speaker, and the AUX and USB ports are at the back. The SRS X2 is apt for a neat desk.

Moving to the JBL family we have the JBL Charge 2, Flip 3, Pulse 2, and the JBL Xtreme. Keep all the speakers together and it looks like the evolution of the *dhol*. One can also imagine Dudley Dursley's life at different stages by looking at these speakers. All the JBL speakers in this list have a similar design – on either side the speakers we have the drivers. The speakers themselves have a cylindrical design with rubber housings

to keep them steady when kept horizontal. There is a slight issue with JBL's designing according to us, because, if you keep the speaker vertically, you might end up blocking one of the drivers.

The JBL Flip 3 is the smallest and narrowest of JBL's lot here. It comes with a flap that covers the USB and auxiliary ports. The speaker is splashproof. The Bluetooth button, volume controllers and call button are textured, and are a part of the speaker grille, making them easy to find without looking at the speaker. The textured finish to the grill is a lot like the UE boom. The JBL Charge 2, on the other hand, has a distinct rubber protrusion that acts as the base. You are encouraged not to keep the speaker vertically. All the buttons are neatly laid out on the top of the speaker (when kept on its intended rubber strip). The speaker has quite a simple design.

If jazzy is what you are looking for, the JBL Pulse 2 is



Logitech UE Boom